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**Tavily raises \$25M to
connect AI agents to the
web**



Companies across many industries are implementing AI agents for internal use, automating a wide range of tasks.

In the financial sector, AI agents are critical for fraud detection. They can analyze vast amounts of transaction data in real time. Meanwhile, sales organizations are using AI agents to gather data on potential customers. These AI sales agents can scour the web and social media for information.

To be effective, these agents need to access the internet and find information from relevant sources, all while following company policies and mirroring how a human researcher would work.

Connecting an agent directly to a large language model like ChatGPT without company-specific safeguards can lead to highly inappropriate results.

“Governance, risk, and compliance at the enterprise is so important now, and if you just let that happen, it’s just going to be the wild, wild west,” George Mathew, managing director at Insight Partners, told TechCrunch.

That’s why Insight Partners led a \$20 million Series A in [Tavily](#), a startup that connects AI agents to the web in a way that’s compliant with company-specific policies. The investment brings the 1-year-old Tavily’s total funding to \$25 million.

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Founded last year by data scientist Rotem Weiss, Tavily began as an open source project he created in 2023 called GPT Researcher. The consumer-focused project fetched real-time web data before ChatGPT was hooked up to the internet, Weiss told TechCrunch. “It went extremely viral, so pretty fast we gained almost 20,000 GitHub stars.”

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Weiss launched Tavily after ChatGPT and other LLMs introduced web search. Unlike GPT Researcher, Tavily focuses on enterprise clients. It provides a suite of tools to companies like Groq, Cohere, MongoDB, and Writer, allowing their agents to search, crawl, and extract structured insights from both public and private sources.

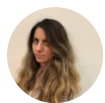
While most AI agents aren’t yet connected to the internet, Weiss says Tavily’s goal is to onboard the next billion agents to the web.

Tavily is not the only startup providing search tools for AI agents. It competes with [Exa](#), which raised a \$17 million Series A from Lightspeed, Nvidia, and Y

Combinator last year. Another smaller startup that offers a web search connectivity layer is [Firecrawl](#). OpenAI and Perplexity are also offering search solutions that are geared toward independent developers.

Topics: [AI](#) [AI agents](#) [Insight Partners](#) [Search](#)

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Marina Temkin

Reporter, Venture |

Marina Temkin is a venture capital and startups reporter at TechCrunch. Prior to joining TechCrunch, she wrote abo...

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AI



OpenAI upgrades
ChatGPT search with
shopping features

OpenAI Updates ChatGPT Search

OpenAI is updating [ChatGPT search](#), its web search tool in ChatGPT, to give users an improved online shopping experience, the company announced Monday.



When ChatGPT users search for products, the chatbot will now offer a few recommendations, present images and reviews for those items, and include direct links to web pages where users can buy the products. OpenAI says users can ask super-specific questions in natural language and receive customized results. To start, OpenAI is experimenting with categories such as fashion, beauty, home goods, and electronics.

IMAGE CREDITS: OPENAI

OpenAI is rolling out the feature in GPT-4o (the default AI model for ChatGPT) on Monday for ChatGPT Pro, Plus, and Free users, as well as for logged-out users around the globe.

The ChatGPT search update is part of OpenAI's effort to compete with rival Google by creating a better, more personalized experience to find products and information on the internet. Online shopping is one of Google's most important businesses, but the advertising market to buy priority placements in Google Search has also contributed to the product's declining quality over the years.

OpenAI claims its search product is growing rapidly. Users made more than a billion web

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searches in ChatGPT last week, the company told TechCrunch.

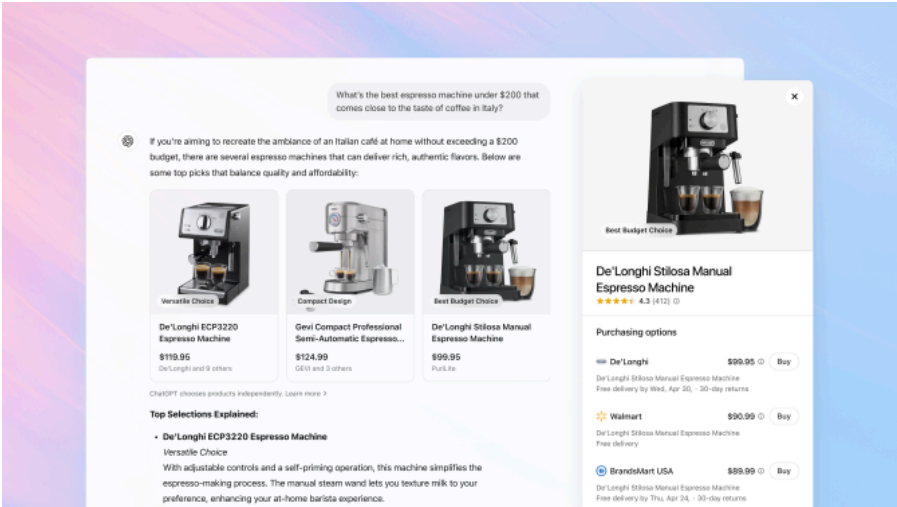


IMAGE CREDITS:OPENAI

OpenAI says it’s determining ChatGPT shopping results independently and notes that ads are not part of this upgrade to ChatGPT search. The shopping results will be based on structured metadata from third parties, such as pricing, product descriptions, and reviews, according to OpenAI. The company won’t receive a kickback from purchases made through ChatGPT search.

OpenAI CEO Sam Altman has historically been against ads in ChatGPT, but in a [recent interview](#) with Stratechery’s Ben Thompson, he changed his tune slightly. Altman said he’d be open to “tasteful” advertising in which OpenAI charges affiliate fees for purchases made through ChatGPT but doesn’t sell priority placement in their results.



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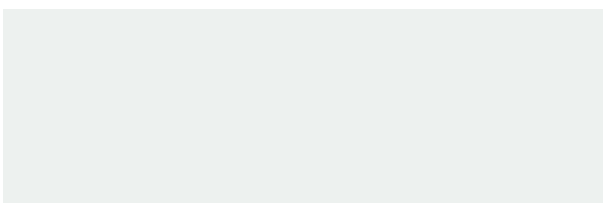
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Soon, OpenAI says it will integrate [its memory feature](#) with shopping for Pro and Plus users, meaning ChatGPT will reference a user's previous chats to make highly personalized product recommendations. The company previously updated ChatGPT to [reference memory when making web searches broadly](#). However, these memory features won't be available to users in the EU, the U.K., Switzerland, Norway, Iceland, and Liechtenstein.

Alongside this update, ChatGPT search will now display trending searches when users start typing a question, much like Google Search's autocomplete feature. Additionally, ChatGPT search has come to WhatsApp, allowing users to message the company's chatbot to get up-to-date answers.

OpenAI has previously explored shopping features via its AI "agent" platform, [Operator](#), which takes anywhere from a few seconds to several minutes to browse dozens of web pages and find relevant products for users. ChatGPT search with shopping is a much faster, hands-on experience and still allows users to search for products using natural language queries.

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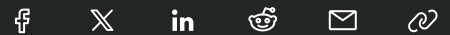
Senior AI Reporter | X

Maxwell Zeff is a senior reporter at TechCrunch specializing in AI. Previously with Gizmodo, Bloomberg,...

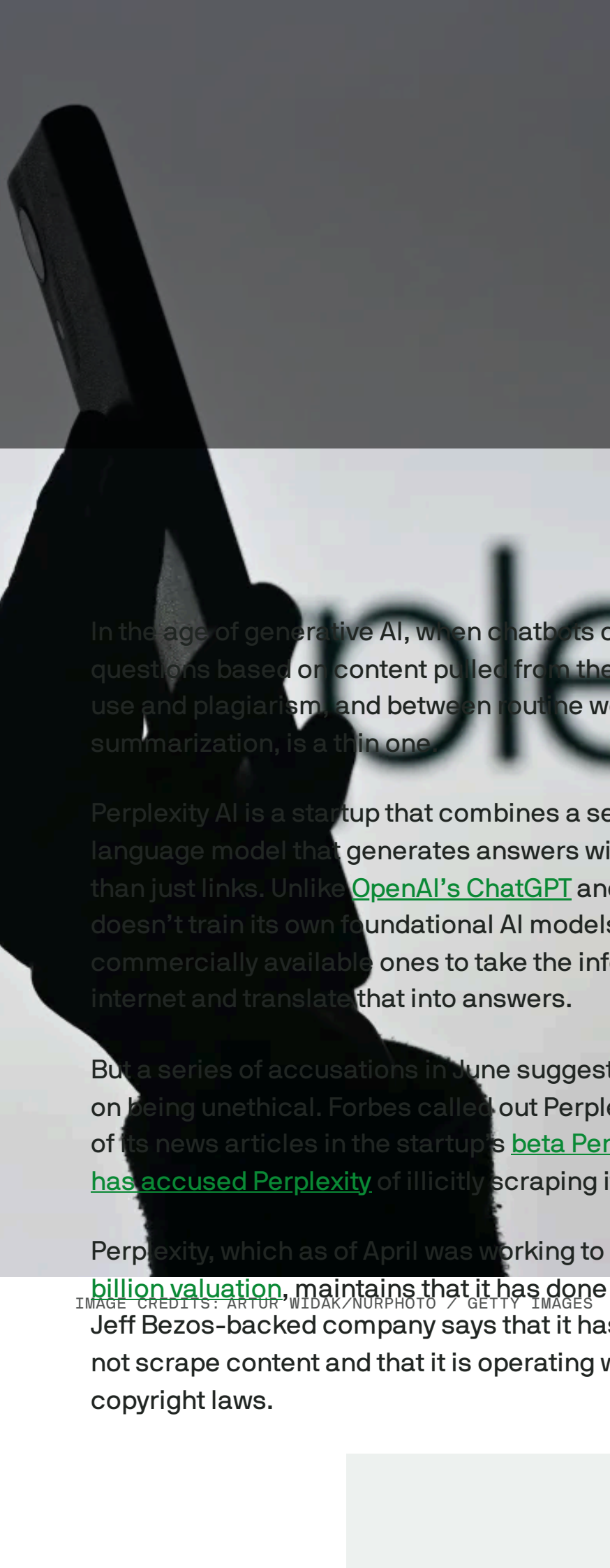
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AI



News outlets are accusing Perplexity of plagiarism and unethical web scraping



Ambiguity around copyright laws and AI web crawlers complicate matters

Rebecca Bellan

8:00 AM PDT · July 2, 2024

In the age of generative AI, when chatbots can provide detailed answers to questions based on content pulled from the internet, the line between fair use and plagiarism, and between routine web scraping and unethical summarization, is a thin one.

Perplexity AI is a startup that combines a search engine with a large language model that generates answers with detailed responses, rather than just links. Unlike [OpenAI's ChatGPT](#) and [Anthropic's Claude](#), Perplexity doesn't train its own foundational AI models, instead using open or commercially available ones to take the information it gathers from the internet and translate that into answers.

But a series of accusations in June suggests the startup's approach borders on being unethical. Forbes called out Perplexity for allegedly plagiarizing one of its news articles in the startup's [beta Perplexity Pages feature](#). And [Wired has accused Perplexity](#) of illicitly scraping its website, along with other sites.

Perplexity, which as of April was working to raise [\\$250 million at a near-\\$3 billion valuation](#), maintains that it has done nothing wrong. The Nvidia- and Jeff Bezos-backed company says that it has honored publishers' requests to not scrape content and that it is operating within the bounds of fair use copyright laws.

IMAGE CREDITS: ARTUR WIDAK/NURPHOTO / GETTY IMAGES

The situation is complicated. At its heart are nuances surrounding two concepts. The first is the Robots Exclusion Protocol, a standard used by websites to indicate that they don't want their content accessed or used by web crawlers. The second is fair use in copyright law, which sets up the legal framework for allowing the use of copyrighted material without permission or payment in certain circumstances.

Surreptitiously scraping web content



IMAGE CREDITS:GETTY IMAGES

Wired's June 19 story claims that Perplexity has ignored the Robots Exclusion Protocol to surreptitiously scrape areas of websites that publishers do not want bots to access. Wired reported that it observed a machine tied to Perplexity doing this on its own news site, as well as across other publications under its parent company, Condé Nast.

The report noted that developer [Robb Knight conducted a similar experiment](#) and came to the same conclusion.



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Both Wired reporters and Knight tested their suspicions by asking Perplexity to summarize a series of URLs and then watching on the server side as an IP address associated with Perplexity visited those sites. Perplexity then “summarized” the text from those URLs — though in the case of one dummy website with limited content that Wired created for this purpose, it returned text from the page verbatim.

This is where the nuances of the Robots Exclusion Protocol come into play.

Web scraping is *technically* when automated pieces of software known as crawlers scour the web to index and collect information from websites. Search engines like Google do this so that web pages can be included in search results. Other companies and researchers use crawlers to gather data from the internet for market analysis, academic research and, as we've come to learn, training machine learning models.

Web scrapers in compliance with this protocol will first look for the “robots.txt” file in a site's source code to see what is permitted and what is not — today, what is not permitted is usually scraping a publisher's site to build massive training datasets for AI. Search engines and AI companies, including Perplexity, have stated that they comply with the protocol, but they aren't legally obligated to do so.

Perplexity's head of business, Dmitry Shevelenko, told TechCrunch that summarizing a URL isn't the same thing as crawling. “Crawling is when you're just going around sucking up information and adding it to your index,”

Shevelenko said. He noted that Perplexity's IP might show up as a visitor to a website that is "otherwise kind of prohibited from robots.txt" only when a user puts a URL into their query, which "doesn't meet the definition of crawling."

"We're just responding to a direct and specific user request to go to that URL," Shevelenko said.

In other words, if a user manually provides a URL to an AI, Perplexity says its AI isn't acting as a web crawler but rather a tool to assist the user in retrieving and processing information they requested.

But to Wired and many other publishers, that's a distinction without a difference because visiting a URL and pulling the information from it to summarize the text sure looks a whole lot like scraping if it's done thousands of times a day.

(Wired also reported that Amazon Web Services, one of Perplexity's cloud service providers, is [investigating the startup](#) for ignoring robots.txt protocol to scrape web pages that users cited in their prompt. AWS told TechCrunch that Wired's report is inaccurate and that it told the outlet it was processing their media inquiry like it does any other report alleging abuse of the service.)

Plagiarism or fair use?

The screenshot shows the Perplexity AI interface. On the left is a sidebar with navigation links: 'New Thread', 'Home', 'Discover', and 'Library'. The main content area features a large image of Eric Schmidt with drones in the background. Below the image is the title 'Eric Schmidt's AI Combat Drones' and a sub-header 'Introduction'. The text describes Schmidt's venture, White Stork/Project Eagle, which aims to revolutionize military technology by creating AI-powered combat drones. At the bottom, there are four related article snippets with their respective sources and read counts.

perplexity

New Thread

Home

Discover

Library

tell me about...

The rabbit r1 will use...

does perplexity pages...

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Eric Schmidt's AI Combat Drones

Curated by Perplexity Team

19 days ago 38,056 2,201

Eric Schmidt, the former CEO of Google, is quietly developing AI-powered combat drones through his secretive venture, initially known as White Stork and now rumored to be called Project Eagle. This initiative aims to revolutionize military technology by creating drones that leverage artificial intelligence for precise target identification and engagement in complex battlefield environments.

Introduction

- Eric Schmidt's Drone Venture
- White Stork/Project Eagle
- AI-Powered Combat Drones
- Testing in Ukraine

Eric Schmidt Hires from Apple, SpaceX and...

forbes • 1

Eric Schmidt poaches from Apple, SpaceX...

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Former Google CEO Eric Schmidt jumps into AI...

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Eric Schmidt's Secret Military Project Reveals...

forbes • 4

Wired and Forbes have also accused Perplexity of plagiarism. Ironically, Wired says [Perplexity plagiarized the very article](#) that called out the startup for surreptitiously scraping its web content.

Wired reporters said the Perplexity chatbot “produced a six-paragraph, [287-word text](#) closely summarizing the conclusions of the story and the evidence used to reach them.” One sentence exactly reproduces a sentence from the original story; Wired says this constitutes plagiarism. [The Poynter Institute’s guidelines](#) say it might be plagiarism if the author (or AI) used seven consecutive words from the original source work.

Forbes also accused Perplexity of plagiarism. The news site published an [investigative report](#) in early June about how Google CEO Eric Schmidt’s new

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[Forbes reported](#) that many of the posts that were curated by the Perplexity team are “strikingly similar to original stories from multiple publications, including Forbes, CNBC and Bloomberg.” Forbes said the posts gathered tens of thousands of views and didn’t mention any of the publications by name in the article text. Rather, Perplexity’s articles included attributions in the form of “small, easy-to-miss logos that link out to them.”

Furthermore, Forbes said the post about Schmidt contains “nearly identical wording” to Forbes’ scoop. The aggregation also included an image created by the Forbes design team that appeared to be slightly modified by Perplexity.

Perplexity CEO Aravind Srinivas responded to Forbes at the time by saying the startup would cite sources more prominently in the future — a solution that’s not foolproof, as citations themselves face technical difficulties. [ChatGPT and other models have hallucinated links](#), and since Perplexity uses OpenAI models, it is likely to be susceptible to such hallucinations. In fact, Wired reported that it observed Perplexity hallucinating entire stories.

Other than noting Perplexity’s “rough edges,” Srinivas and the company have largely doubled down on Perplexity’s right to use such content for summarizations.

This is where the nuances of fair use come into play. Plagiarism, while frowned upon, is not technically illegal.

According to the [U.S. Copyright Office](#), it is legal to use limited portions of a work including quotes for purposes like commentary, criticism, news reporting and scholarly reports. AI companies like Perplexity posit that providing a summary of an article is within the bounds of fair use.

“Nobody has a monopoly on facts,” Shevelenko said. “Once facts are out in the open, they are for everyone to use.”

Shevelenko likened Perplexity’s summaries to how journalists often use information from other news sources to bolster their own reporting. The unfair advantage of AI companies, however, is that they can compile in seconds what it took several journalists hours to create.

Mark McKenna, a professor of law at the UCLA Institute for Technology, Law & Policy, told TechCrunch the situation isn’t an easy one to untangle. In a fair use case, courts would weigh whether the summary uses a lot of the expression of the original article, versus just the ideas. They might also examine whether reading the summary might be a substitute for reading the article.

“There are no bright lines,” McKenna said. “So [Perplexity] saying factually what an article says or what it reports would be using non-copyrightable aspects of the work. That would be just facts and ideas. But the more that the summary includes actual expression and text, the more that starts to look like reproduction, rather than just a summary.”

Unfortunately for publishers, unless Perplexity is using full expressions (and apparently, in some cases, it is), its summaries might not be considered a violation of fair use.

How Perplexity aims to protect itself

AI companies like [OpenAI have signed media deals](#) with a range of news publishers to access their current and archival content on which to train their algorithms. In return, OpenAI promises to surface news articles from those publishers in response to user queries in ChatGPT. (But even that [has some kinks that need to be worked out](#), as Nieman Lab reported last week.)

Perplexity has held off from announcing its own slew of media deals, perhaps waiting for the accusations against it to blow over. But the company is “full speed ahead” on a series of advertising revenue-sharing deals with publishers.

The idea is that Perplexity will start including ads alongside query responses, and publishers that have content cited in any answer will get a slice of the corresponding ad revenue. Shevelenko said Perplexity is also working to allow publishers access to its technology so they can build Q&A experiences and power things like related questions natively inside their sites and products.

But is this just a fig leaf for systemic IP theft? Perplexity isn’t the only chatbot that threatens to summarize content so completely that readers fail to see the need to click out to the original source material.

And if AI scrapers like this continue to take publishers’ work and repurpose it for their own businesses, publishers will have a harder time earning ad dollars. That means eventually, there will be less content to scrape. When there’s no more content left to scrape, generative AI systems will then pivot to training on synthetic data, which could lead to a [hellish feedback loop](#) of potentially biased and inaccurate content.

Topics: [AI](#) [Media & Entertainment](#) [Perplexity AI](#) [Startups](#) [web scraping](#)



Rebecca Bellan

Senior Reporter |

Rebecca Bellan is a senior reporter at TechCrunch, where she covers Tesla and Elon Musk's broader empire, autonomy, AI, electrification, gig work platforms, Big Tech regulatory scrutiny, and more. She's on...

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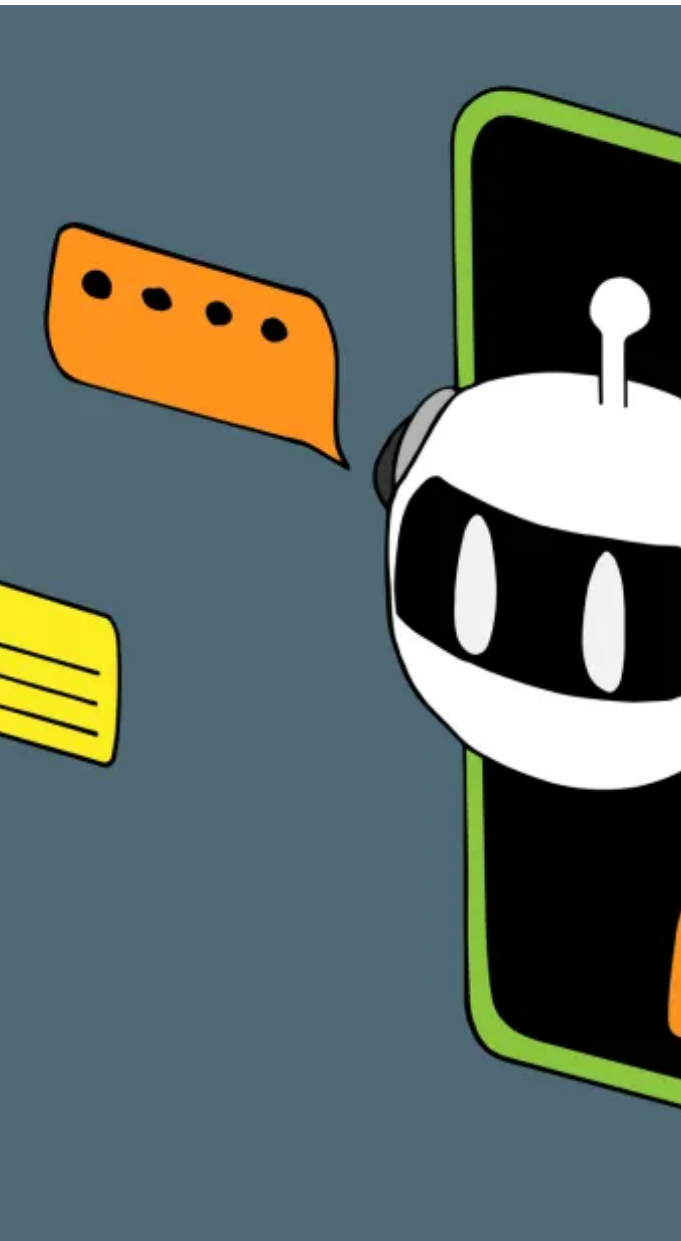


IMAGE CREDITS: MALORNY / GETTY IMAGES

AI



OpenAI's Operator agent helped me move, but I had to help it, too

Maxwell Zeff — 7:00 AM PST · February 4, 2025

OpenAI gave me one week to test [its new AI agent, Operator](#), a system that can independently do tasks for you on the internet.

Operator is the closest thing I've seen to the tech industry's [vision of AI agents](#) — systems that can automate the boring parts of life, freeing us up to do

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the things we really love. However, judging from my experience with OpenAI's agent, truly "autonomous" AI systems are still just out of reach.

OpenAI [trained a new model to power Operator](#), which combines the visual understanding of GPT-4o with the reasoning capabilities of o1.

That model seems to work well for basic tasks; I watched Operator click buttons, navigate menus on websites, and fill out forms. The AI was occasionally successful at independently taking actions, and it works much faster than web-based agents I've seen from [Anthropic](#) and [Google](#).

But during my trial, I found myself assisting OpenAI's agent more than I'd like. It felt like I was coaching Operator through each problem, whereas I wanted to push certain tasks off my plate altogether.

Too often during my test, I had to answer several questions, grant permissions, fill out personal information, and help the agent when it got stuck.

In car terms, Operator is like driving a car with cruise control — occasionally taking your foot off the pedals and letting the car drive itself — but it's far from full-blown autopilot.

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In fact, OpenAI says Operator’s frequent pauses are by design.

The AI powering Operator, much like the AI powering chatbots like OpenAI’s ChatGPT, can’t reliably work independently for long periods of time, and it’s prone to the same sort of hallucinating. Because of that, OpenAI doesn’t want to give the system too much decision-making power or sensitive user information. Maybe that’s a safe choice by OpenAI, but it reduces Operator’s practicality.

That said, OpenAI’s first agent is an impressive proof of concept — and interface — for an AI that can use the front end of any website. But to create truly independent AI systems, tech companies will need to build more reliable AI models that don’t require this much steering.

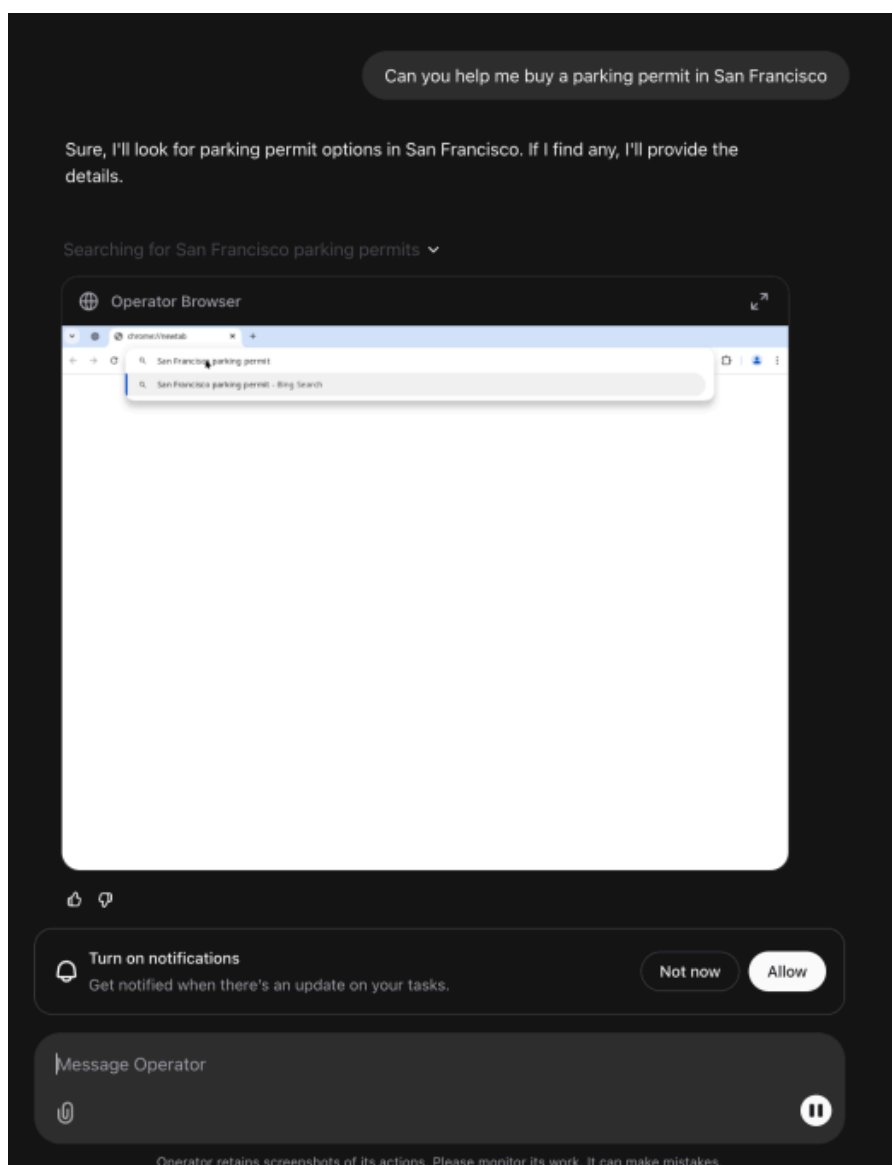
A little too “hands on”

My Operator trial coincided with the week I was moving apartments, so I had OpenAI’s agent help with moving logistics.

I asked Operator to help me buy a new parking permit. OpenAI’s agent told me, “Sure,” then opened a window into its browser on my PC’s screen.

Operator then conducted a search for a San Francisco parking permit in the browser, took me to the correct city website, and even the right page.

Operator still lets you use the rest of your computer while it's working, something that can't be said for Google's Project Mariner. This is because OpenAI's agent isn't really working on the computer, but rather, off in the cloud somewhere.



THE OPERATOR INTERFACE

IMAGE CREDITS: MAXWELL ZEFF AND OPENAI

For my parking permit, I had to grant Operator permission to start different processes a few too many times. It also stopped to ask me to fill out forms with personal information — such as my name, phone number, and email address. At times, Operator also got lost, forcing me to take control of the browser and get the agent back on track.

In another test, I asked Operator to make me a reservation at a Greek restaurant. To its credit, Operator found me a nice place in my area with

reasonable prices. But I had to answer more than half a dozen questions throughout the flow.

SOME STEPS TO MAKING A RESERVATION WITH OPERATOR

IMAGE CREDITS:MAXWELL ZEFF AND OPENAI

If you have to intervene six or more times just to book a reservation through an AI agent, at what point is it easier to just do it yourself? That's a question I asked myself a lot while testing Operator.

Agent-as-a-platform

In a few of my tests, I ran into websites that blocked Operator for whatever reason. For example, I tried booking an electrician using TaskRabbit, but OpenAI's agent told me that it ran into an error, and asked if it could use an alternative service instead. Expedia, Reddit, and YouTube also blocked the AI agent from accessing their platforms.

However, other services are embracing Operator with open arms. Instacart, Uber, and eBay collaborated with OpenAI for the launch of

Operator, allowing the agent to navigate their websites on behalf of humans.

These businesses are preparing for a future where a subset of user interactions are facilitated by an AI agent.

“Customers are using Instacart through a variety of different entry points,” said Daniel Danker, chief product officer at Instacart, in an interview with TechCrunch. “We see Operator as, potentially, another one of those entry points.”

Letting OpenAI’s agent use Instacart’s website on behalf of a person seems like it would separate Instacart from its customers. However, Danker says Instacart wants to meet customers wherever they are.

“We really are bullish about our belief, similar to OpenAI, that agentic systems will have a major impact on how consumers interact with digital properties,” said eBay’s chief AI officer, Nitzan Mekel-Bobrov, in an interview with TechCrunch.

Even if AI agents rise in popularity, Mekel-Bobrov says he expects users will always come to eBay’s website, noting that “online destinations are not going anywhere.”

Trust issues

I had some issues trusting Operator after it hallucinated a few times, and nearly cost me several hundreds dollars.

For instance, I asked the agent to find me a parking garage near my new apartment. It ended up suggesting two garages that it said would take just a few minutes to walk to.

HALLUCINATION ABOUT PARKING SPOT DISTANCES

IMAGE CREDITS:MAXWELL ZEFF AND OPENAI

Besides being way out of my price range, the garages were actually really far from my apartment. One was a 20-minute walk away, and the other was a 30-minute walk. Turns out, Operator had put in the wrong address.

This is exactly why OpenAI doesn't give its agent your credit card number, passwords, or access to email. If OpenAI didn't let me intervene here, Operator would've wasted hundreds of dollars on a parking spot I didn't need.

Hallucinations like this are a key roadblock to actually useful autonomous agents — ones that can take bothersome tasks off your plate. No one will trust agents if they're prone to making basic

mistakes, especially mistakes with real-world consequences.

With Operator, OpenAI seems to have built some impressive tools to let AI systems browse the web. But these tools won't amount to much until the underpinning AI can reliably do what users ask it to do. Until then, humans will be stuck assisting agents — not the other way around. And that kind of defeats the point.

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Senior AI Reporter |

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